

MONTH 1 - PERSPECTIVE AND CONSTRUCTION

This month focuses on developing an understanding of perspective and construction. Perspective, being one of the most important fundamentals in drawing, describes the depth and coherence in a scene. Construction refers to manipulating primitive forms—using tools such as “cutting” and “extruding”.

This month’s exercises will help you hone your skills to effectively create drawings with structure and provide a foundation for constructing human figures, animals, and complex scenes with solid, believable structure.

Week 1 - Boxes and cylinder

Drawing primitive forms such as boxes and cylinders is the first step to drawing anything in a way that confidently represents perspective, depth, and solidity. Look to explore different angles as you rotate boxes, paying close attention to changes in the shapes and angles within the planes you draw. For cylinders, pay attention to the degree of the curves of the circular planes as they move and rotate in space.

Week 2 - Cut boxes, cut cylinders and silhouette boxes

Cutting primitive forms ties the concept of construction into your primitive forms, allowing you to add a bit of complexity. In this sense, you’re manipulating your primitive forms in a controlled, calculated way. Consider designing the shape of the cuts you’d like to make, then extrude them in perspective across your primitive forms. Drawing silhouette boxes is an exercise designed to assign importance to the angle of the silhouette of your box. Notice how you can clearly depict the rotation of a box without its interior lines.

Week 3 - Primitive forms in the same space

In addition to drawing primitive forms independently, placing primitive forms in the same space or environment allows you to convey a sense of solid reality within a scene. Keep an eye on the horizon line and center of vision, as they are crucial concepts when constructing coherent scenes in perspective.

Week 4 - Primitive forms drawn using guidelines in perspective

Similar to cutting primitive forms, using guidelines in perspective allows you to construct a more organic primitive form by extruding a shape in perspective. To complete this exercise, start by drawing a two-dimensional shape in perspective and identify its line breaks. From those points, draw out the guidelines in perspective, ensuring that they all converge toward a vanishing point. Then conclude by drawing in the back plane.

Week 5 - Human figures constructed with primitive forms and animals constructed with primitive forms

When drawing primitive forms to construct human figures and animals, use all of the tools and exercises from this month and implement them into your mannequinized subjects. Think of combining primitive forms in a single space, manipulating them using cuts or guidelines in perspective, and effectively sizing and overlapping them to construct your subject.

MONTH 2 - VISUAL COORDINATION

This month focuses on developing visual coordination—training meant to build accuracy when replicating proportions, measurements, and spatial relationships. By observing and making careful calculations, you strengthen your ability to translate what you see into confident, precise drawings.

Week 6 - Point of view drawings from life

Having good visual coordination means being able to accurately represent the proportions and measurements of what you see on the page in your drawing. Connecting perspective and construction to visual coordination, we move forward with point of view drawings from life. For this exercise, grab your sketchbook and find an interesting scene to draw. Be sure to keep the five-point perspective grid in mind for any point of view drawing you do, to ensure that the perspective grid you're drawing in is curvilinear.

Week 7 - Silhouettes and copied images

One of the most effective exercises when it comes to strengthening your visual coordination is simply drawing silhouettes. From life or from an image, find your subject and draw only the exterior shape, ignoring all interior details and overlaps. This will make up the silhouette. For extra mileage, find a bunch of images that interest you and copy them. The level of detail you draw in the images is up to your discretion.

Week 8 - Faces and reflections

Moving forward with visual coordination—strengthening exercises, this week focuses specifically on faces. Since they're a very common point of interest, and slight mistakes in measurements make a big impact when drawing them, they make up the first half of this week's exercises. Reflections will help develop your measurement-making process, sharpening your eye. Draw a straight vertical or horizontal line, and a random shape on one side. Then, accurately redraw that shape on the opposite side of the line, matching it as closely as possible in a mirrored orientation.

Week 9 - Drawings referenced from Kim Jung Gi

To honor one of the greatest artists to exist, this week is dedicated to studying master Kim Jung Gi's artwork. Moving forward with our image-copying exercises, this week will be especially beneficial, as you might pick up on some of the masterful techniques Kim Jung Gi uses in his linework, so pay very close attention.

MONTH 3 - SHAPES AND LINES

This month focuses on developing intuition for appealing shape design and line quality. You'll build a sense of flow, rhythm, and compositional relationships, applying them in practice to hair, face, and human figure studies. Shape design and line usage are by far one of the most important pairs of fundamentals, as they are applied to any drawing you will ever create.

Week 10 - Pages of controlled lines, single-line drawings and value-line drawings

This month focuses on developing your intuition for appealing shape design and line quality. Drawing pages of controlled lines is an exercise designed to slow down your thought process when it comes to line drawings. Take the time to closely analyze the relationships between the lines you make. Single-line drawings are meant to push this exercise closer to its application. For this exercise, draw your subject using a single line, without lifting your pen or stylus. This will help simplify the line economy in your drawings, limiting your lines to the most important ones. By differentiating value lines from silhouette, contour, overlap, and form lines, practice drawing your references with the goal of representing value only. This will help add depth to your drawings in a way you might not have explored before.

Week 11 - Organic shape designs and distilled bubbles

Putting a focus on drawing appealing shapes, isolating organic shape designs as an exercise gives you the practice you need to create fluid, natural shapes that you can apply in almost any other drawing you make. Keep in mind that the goal of this exercise is organicity. Therefore, do your best to avoid any geometric qualities in your shape designs, such as repeated shapes, parallel lines, and right angles. Practice drawing sets of distilled bubbles to get a sense for strong organic compositions. Do this by drawing many circles or spheres in a flowing, continuous motion. This will help build your intuition for breaking rhythm and creating random patterns in your drawing. When drawing your sets of distilled bubbles, count each set as one item, with each set containing roughly seven to twelve bubbles.

Week 12 - Shape-strong hair and shape-strong faces

To put your shape designs and organic compositions into application, use them to guide your decisions and complete studies where you exaggerate shapes in hair and faces. This exercise is similar to drawing caricatures but takes a more technical approach, focusing on strong, organic shape designs.

Week 13 - Human figures drawn with geometric shapes and human figures drawn with strong organic shapes

Shifting our approach, drawing human figures with geometric shapes does not focus on shape design. Rather, it highlights the major shapes in a figure. Whether these shapes represent form or value, simplify them to an extreme level, to the point where they become almost unrecognizable. This exercise will help reduce the visual information in an image, making it easier to identify the larger organic shapes in the second exercise. Drawing human figures with strong organic shapes builds on those simple geometric shapes, using them as a base to create more organic, flowing forms.

MONTH 4 - FORM

This month focuses on developing a clear understanding of form and volume. You'll build awareness of overlaps and depth while exploring different ways to use your lines to convey form, gradually shifting from simple organic forms to people, animals, and organic materials.

Week 14 - Organic forms overlapping

To prepare for more complex form drawing, drawing simple organic forms overlapping helps isolate the feeling of bringing your shapes to life, giving them three-dimensional volume. A quick way to add volume and depth to your forms is by sketching in the terminator shadow, keeping the direction of the light source in mind to guide your cast shadows. As you overlap your forms, pay close attention to the overlap lines and the angles at which they intersect. Stronger angles, such as ninety degrees, help show pronounced overlap, whereas weaker angles, such as twenty degrees, convey a more subtle overlap. See if you can create a sense of depth with form drawing alone.

Week 15 - Organic forms drawn with ellipses

This week focuses on building a strong connection between your mind and your awareness of the forms you're drawing. Tracing ellipses around the forms you draw to define contour lines will force you to consider the invisible wireframe of your forms. This will give you a very solid understanding when drawing simple organic forms, allowing you to draw with more confidence.

Week 16 - People or animals drawn with simplified organic forms

Moving forward, you can now apply your organic form drawings to people and animals. This will help simplify poses as you learn to manage basic forms and overlaps to accurately depict depth and volume.

Week 17 - Organic material studies

Organic material studies focus primarily on depicting forms that may contain more subtle overlaps. This means you're not simplifying as much as you would in the previous weeks. For references, find images containing folds, such as drapery, clothing, and bags.

Week 18 - Anatomical form studies

Study the human figure with the goal of purely representing form and volume. The challenge is to accurately differentiate subtle and prominent overlaps within the forms of human anatomy. That being said, it's up to your discretion how much detail you include in the anatomy. Do your best to recall the exercises from the previous weeks of this month and apply them in your studies.

MONTH 5 - GESTURE

This month focuses on developing a strong sense of gesture and movement in human figure drawing. You'll learn to capture the energy and flow of poses while gradually adding structure, volume, and subtle anatomical information. Using exercises like triangle gestures provides a solid foundation to help you understand how shape design connects to gesture. This will keep your drawings fluid and readable as you move from quick sketches to longer, more detailed gestures.

Week 19 - Thirty-second gestures and triangle gestures

With gesture drawing, the goal is to feel the pose rather than draw it exactly as it is. A short time setting forces you to focus on the most important information, rather than capturing the motion and energy of every detail of anatomy. Shoulder and hip tilts are a great place to start, as they convey a lot of information and can often be represented with just two lines. Triangle gestures are drawn without a time limit. The goal of this exercise is to quickly represent a pose using triangles alone—a simple shape that effectively represents gesture and avoids stiffness. Typically, they are completed using five to seven triangles for the limbs and torso, and a circle for the head.

Week 20 - One-minute gestures and triangle gestures

One minute gestures should give you enough time to rough out the general pose with a bit more precision and accuracy. If you still feel like one minute is not enough time for you, lower the opacity of your reference and plan the shapes and lines of your gesture by tracing over your reference. Then, use your planned gesture as a reference and start your one minute timer. Triangle gestures should always be drawn with the intention to represent gesture. This means that the direction of the triangles must always be pointing in the direction of the energy in the pose, typically away from the character as shown in the prompt examples.

Week 21 - Two-minute gestures and triangle gestures

At this point, two minutes should feel like a long time for your gesture studies. You can begin to introduce value lines and block out larger forms in the pose as you continue to capture its motion and energy. Defining anatomy shouldn't be a priority yet, but lightly hinting at muscle groups is helpful if it helps add important information to the pose. Triangle gestures should continue to influence how you approach your time-limited gestures. Keep them as simple as possible, and avoid overcomplicating the process.

Week 22 - Five-minute gestures

With five minutes, you should have enough time to focus on three main priorities. The first is using your triangle gestures as a base to bring fluid, organic shapes into your figure, giving it the energy required to read as a gesture drawing. The second priority is blocking out the major forms using value lines, contour lines, and overlap lines. This helps add depth and anatomical accuracy to your gesture. The third priority ties everything together by ensuring your shapes remain organic and that smaller details are integrated well into the larger shapes and forms of the gesture drawing.

MONTH 6 - ANATOMY

This month focuses on studying the human body's anatomy. You'll explore the torso, arms, hands, head, feet, legs, and hips, paying attention to the shapes of muscles, tendons, and bones. You'll also observe how fat deposits interact with these structures. The goal is to develop a solid understanding of anatomy to make your figures more believable and grounded in reality.

Week 23 - Torso studies

Studying anatomy as a concept can get very complicated, depending on how in-depth you want to go into muscles, tendons, bone structure, etc. For this week, the focus is torso studies. You can look into the muscle groups of the chest, abdomen, obliques, serratus anterior group, and back, and vary your studies by including skeletal structures such as the ribcage, clavicles, and scapula.

Week 24 - Hand studies, arm studies and head studies

When studying anatomy, one of the most effective approaches is examining the shapes of muscle groups, treating them as you would in the organic shape design exercise from week eleven. For hands, focus on exploring the muscles around the thumb and pinkie finger, the fingers themselves, and how the hand attaches to the wrist. Studying the anatomy in the arms helps you better understand the underlying muscle structure and their shapes. For head studies, observe how muscles, fat, and bone structure influence the distinct qualities of a face.

Week 25 - Foot studies, leg studies and hip studies

One of the major distinctions of the feet is the shape of the sole, along with the toes and the tendons attached to them, including the flexors and extensors. For the legs, focus on understanding the underlying anatomy of the quadriceps, hamstrings, gastrocnemius, and soleus muscles, as well as the tendons around the ankle and knee, such as the patellar and Achilles tendons. Simplifying the muscle groups in the thighs and lower leg can also be effective, as you won't always need to depict each individual muscle.

Week 26 - Body fat anatomy studies

Moving on to studying body fat, the key is identifying fat deposits and observing how they change depending on different body types. You don't need to go too in-depth for full-body studies, but when isolating specific limbs or body parts, take the time to notice how fat, muscles, tendons, and bones interact and show through the surface of the skin.

MONTH 7 - ANIMALS

This month focuses on building a solid understanding of animals by combining construction, form, gesture, and anatomy. You will start by breaking animals down into primitive forms to understand their structure, then explore the larger organic volumes to see how the forms overlap. Pay attention to motion and gesture to capture energy and fluidity, and study the underlying bones, muscles, and tendons to increase your knowledge of anatomy. By integrating all of these concepts and fundamentals, your animal studies will become more structured, dynamic, and lifelike.

Week 27 - Animal construction studies

This week's exercise focuses on studying the structure of animals through the lens of perspective and construction. Similar to the exercises from the first month of C52, animals will be constructed using primitive forms. Keep in mind the tools used in previous exercises, such as cutting, extruding using guidelines in perspective, and overlapping primitive forms. Try picking only a couple of animals for this month so you can build a solid understanding of each, rather than spreading your focus too thin.

Week 28 - Animal form studies

Shifting our lens to studying form, break down your references into larger organic volumes to simplify your subject into forms. This will help give you a better understanding of the characteristics of the larger forms in the animals you select, as well as insight into how they overlap. Consider using contour lines and ellipses to help build a strong connection between your mind and the forms you draw. Lastly, value lines can greatly help with depicting form if placed correctly.

Week 29 - Animal gesture studies

Study the motion and gesture found in the animals of your choice and set a time limit if you find yourself spending too long on each drawing. This will help you maintain the same sense of energy found in the gesture exercises from previous weeks. Consider using triangle gestures to structure your animal gestures and improve fluidity.

Week 30 - Animal anatomy studies

This week's focus brings animal anatomy into the mix. Do your best to find references that show the bones, tendons, and muscles of the animals you selected to better understand their underlying structures. Gaining a deeper understanding this way will improve your drawings, even if you don't end up drawing detailed anatomical information—often in ways you may not notice right away.

Week 31 - Animal studies drawn implementing construction, form, gesture and anatomy

To put the last four weeks' exercises into application, this week you will be combining all of your tools into individual studies. Think of construction as a way to give your drawings structure and solidity, and form as a tool to bring depth and volume. Gesture helps add motion and fluidity to your shapes, while anatomy gives your drawings more believability and accuracy.

MONTH 8 - CLOTHES AND PROPS

This month focuses on expanding your visual library for clothing, armor, weapons, and accessories. You'll identify cultural and functional differences and observe how different civilizations and cultures approach design and unique visual details. Building up your visual library means learning to recognize shapes and forms through careful observation. Orthographics are definitely something to explore when studying design.

Week 32 - Warm-climate clothes studies

To build up our visual library, this week focuses on studying clothes people wear in warm or hot climates. There aren't strict rules on what you should study—look at shirts, shorts, sandals, and similar items. To really deepen your knowledge, explore clothing from different cultures to vary what you can draw. Look for visual anchor points that serve as quick identifiers for the type of clothing you want to draw.

Week 33 - Cold-climate clothes studies

Continuing to add to our visual library, we now focus on studying clothes designed for cold weather. Think coats, boots, hats, scarves, and similar items. Compare past attire to modern clothing and notice the differences. Recall the concepts and fundamentals from the earlier months of the challenge to complete these studies with more accuracy.

Week 34 - Armor studies

The exercise for this week focuses on studying armor. Whether it's modern or ancient, be sure to vary the types of armor you study. Think of different civilizations and the visual anchor points that vary across their armor pieces. Each culture's unique "style" is worth paying attention to, as it can take your character designs to the next level.

Week 35 - Weapon and accessory studies

We end this month's exercises with studies focused on building our visual library for weapons and accessories. When studying weapons, keep in mind that the goal is to learn to recognize their shapes and details, rather than drawing them in perspective. It's recommended to study them using orthographic drawings instead. Accessories is a broad term, so feel free to explore items like tools, devices, headgear, and more.

MONTH 9 - MACHINES AND VEHICLES

This month centers on understanding industrial design and mechanical structure, building your visual library. The focus is learning how to simplify complex, geometric subjects while maintaining clarity, form, and appeal. By studying a range of machines and vehicles, you'll build an eye for mechanical anatomy, design patterns, and functional shapes.

Week 36 - Machine studies

This month highlights the importance of industrial design in your drawings. Communicating complex, geometric designs is not easy, especially if you've never tried it before. This week focuses on studying machines—meaning any object that displays some form of mechanical anatomy. This can range from close-up studies of mechanical joints to larger objects like sewing machines.

Week 37 - Car studies and motorcycle studies

As we continue to expand our visual library, car and motorcycle studies can be useful to study as they force you to condense high-detail information into something simpler and easier to read, allowing it to be communicated clearly without taking forever to draw.

Week 38 - Boat studies and plane studies

This week focuses on boats and planes. For these studies, feel free to draw them either orthographically or in perspective. Both approaches are useful, but they serve different purposes. Orthographic studies focus on design elements, whereas in-perspective studies target form, detail simplification, and constructing objects in perspective.

Week 39 - Designed machines or vehicles

Design your own machines or vehicles. They don't need to be complicated, nor do they need to function correctly. The point of this exercise is to replicate the patterns in mechanical anatomy you've studied in recent weeks and put them into application. Remember to implement the tools from the earlier months of the challenge to help your designs read clearly with appeal.

MONTH 10 - ENVIRONMENTS

This month focuses on honing your ability to depict environments and integrate characters within them. You'll explore natural settings, architectural styles from different regions, and plant life. On top of this, you'll learn ways to simplify complex forms and textures in an environment and identify visual anchor points. The main goal is to get comfortable drawing things beyond human figures and animals—broadening your reach and exploring is key for development.

Week 40 - Natural environment studies

This exercise allows you to play with drawing organic forms and textures to represent an environment. You might be tempted to start painting at this point, but it is more beneficial to stick to drawing this month in order to properly solidify your understanding of effectively using your lines to convey your ideas. This week, focus on finding interesting natural environments containing trees, grass, rocks, mountains, and more. Work on breaking down complex noise and visual information using only your lines.

Week 41 - European architecture studies, East Asian architecture studies and Wild Western architecture studies

Explore the various architectural styles across different regions. Look for shapes and designs that might define a stereotypical visual anchor point—something that will convey an idea at first glance. There's no need to draw every single detail or entire buildings or infrastructure. Studies as simple as rooftops or doors can teach you more than spending a long time on a whole building. You can also explore how buildings fit into their environments, considering their practical, aesthetic, and cultural values. Blurring the line between architecture and furniture, feel free to complete some "interior architecture" studies, observing things like fireplaces, tables, chairs, and more.

Week 42 - Tree studies and plant studies

This week focuses specifically on drawing greenery and plant life. Consider the different types of trees and identify what defines them from a design standpoint. Look for gestural lines and appealing shapes that can help simplify the trunk, and use value lines or form lines to quickly and effectively represent foliage. For each study, decide whether you want to draw multiple plants grouped together—like a field of flowers—or focus on individual plants. Explore and discover new plants you might not have seen before—you never know where they might fit into a drawing.

Week 43 - Environments featuring multiple people

This week's goal is to get comfortable placing characters into environments from imagination. Include animals, buildings, and even abstract organic forms in your scenes before adding your characters. You can place characters both near and far to help convey depth without needing to fill the scene with too many surroundings. You'll notice that making a scene from imagination work boils down to scaling objects correctly in perspective. Be sure to pay attention mainly to the center of vision, and your perspective grid. Feel free to use references if they help give you ideas.

Week 44 - Composition studies

Consider composition as a tool to guide movement and organize visual information. When used effectively, it can help convey a feeling, concept, or story. This week, find references from movie scenes and study how they use compositional ratios to convey intentional movement, gesture, lighting, and resting space, while playing with different contrasts.

MONTH 11 - VALUES

This month focuses on building accuracy in value identification and distillation, improving visual and compositional clarity, and training you to simplify and make intentional painting decisions. By the end, you should have a solid foundation in painting with a clearer understanding of what matters most.

Week 45 - Two-value paintings

Moving into the final two months of the challenge, this month focuses on values. Starting with two-value studies, find references and paint them using only black (or dark grey) and white (or light grey). The purpose of this exercise is to break down a reference into a simpler value structure, increasing accuracy in value identification and value distillations. Two-value structures are extremely important in painting, as they play a big role during the thumbnail stage of the creative illustration process and remain crucial in final pieces for visual and compositional clarity. If you find this exercise challenging, find grayscale references with large value shapes, minimal gradients or soft edges, and high value contrast.

Week 46 - Three-value paintings

This week allows you to use third value, introducing a midtone in your painting. Consider this when selecting your reference: if the value statements in the reference are already very clear, you will not need to think as hard to distill the values and simplify the value structure. You should feel somewhat liberated, being able to use this third value in contrast to the first week.

Week 47 - References painted with limited brushstrokes in grayscale

Rather than limiting the number of values in a painting, this week shifts to limiting how many brushstrokes you lay down on the canvas. You can do this exercise digitally or traditionally. When working digitally, refrain from using heavy texture brushes; a hard round brush with opacity is sufficient. This exercise focuses on the concept of stroke or brush economy, highlighting the importance of simplifying shapes in your painting and painting with more intention. It should force you to think more than you paint. Aim for 15-30 brushstrokes per study, however there is no strict guideline.

Week 48 - References painted in grayscale

After practicing limiting both the values and brushstrokes in your paintings, try using these ideas in a full-value painting. You may use as many brushstrokes as you want. Having the idea in mind that you have unlimited number of values and brushstrokes at your disposal can very often lead to overcomplicated paintings with messy value structures. Even though you could use thousands of brushstrokes to create soft edges, textures, and complex values, make good decisions to keep your paintings rather simple. Not all good paintings are complicated—a great painter can convey their ideas simply and effectively.

MONTH 12 - COLOR

This month focuses on applying color with intention while reinforcing strong value structure, limited brushstrokes, and appealing graphic readability. You will learn to make deliberate color decisions based on hue, saturation, and brightness (value), while avoiding the tendency to overcomplicate your paintings. This month ties together all of the challenge's covered concepts and fundamentals into a finalized colored illustration!

Week 49 - Three-color paintings and five-color paintings

Very similar to the limited value studies from last month's exercises, this month introduces color. You'll be forced to make decisions by choosing colors based on their hue, saturation, and brightness (value). The goal is to let go of the intuitive need to find the perfect color and instead base your judgments more heavily on value alone. Three-color paintings should feel similar to the three-value paintings from the previous month, while five-color paintings should feel like a breather—choose five colors and paint your reference carefully. Once again, no brush opacity is permitted for this exercise; use a hard brush to create clear, graphic shapes.

Week 50 - References painted with limited brushstrokes in color

Select your references, then paint them in color using a limited number of brushstrokes. Consider each brushstroke to be extremely valuable—you don't want to waste them. Take the time to carefully design their size, opacity, direction, and shape. Pay close attention to the order in which you layer your brushstrokes and how that order affects the final result.

Week 51 - Painted references in color

This week focuses on tying all of the painting concepts and exercises together—values, brushstrokes, color, and graphic shapes. Paint your references in color, but be conscious of these elements and avoid overcomplicating things.

Week 52 - Create a finalized colored illustration

The final week of Challenge 52 gives you the opportunity to take a full week to create a finalized, colored illustration. Feel free to draw or paint whatever you want—this should feel like completing one of your own ideas while combining all of the concepts and fundamentals from Challenge 52. You may work in any style you like, and either color your linework, combine line art with painting, or fully paint the piece. Once finished, you've officially completed Challenge 52—congratulations!